

Friend-friend dialogue (Topic: Dunning-Kruger effect)

Friend A:

Friend B:

你听说过邓宁-克鲁格效应吗？我最近在看一篇文章，觉得特别有意思，它讲的是人们对自己能力的认知偏差。

Have you heard of the Dunning-Kruger effect? I recently read an article about it and found it very interesting. It is about people's cognitive bias in judging their own abilities.

噢，邓宁-克鲁格效应听起来挺复杂的，能不能简单说说是啥？

Oh, the Dunning-Kruger effect sounds quite complicated. Could you briefly explain what it is?

当然。简单来说，就是能力低的人往往会高估自己，而能力强的人反而可能低估自己。比如有些人做错很多事，却特别自信。

Of course. Simply put, people with low ability often overestimate themselves, while people with high ability may instead underestimate themselves. For example, some people make many mistakes but still feel very confident.

哇，这听起来蛮符合生活中的现象啊。它是怎么被发现的？有实验支持吗？

Wow, that sounds very consistent with what we see in everyday life. How was it discovered? Is there experimental evidence?

有的！1999年，两个心理学家邓宁和克鲁格做了一个实验，让参与者完成能力测试，然后预测自己答对了多少题，还要估计自己在所有人中的排名。结果发现，成绩最差的那部分人高估了自己大概30个百分点。

Yes. In 1999, two psychologists, Dunning and Kruger, conducted an experiment in which participants completed ability tests, predicted how many questions they had answered correctly, and estimated their ranking among all participants. The results showed that those with the lowest performance overestimated themselves by about 30 percentage points.

哇，30个百分点。那能力强的人呢？他们也会犯错吗？

Wow, 30 percentage points. What about people with high ability? Do they also make mistakes?

是的，反而他们会低估自己。他们觉得别人也像自己一样厉害，所以没意识到自己的优势，这个叫做虚假一致性效应。

Yes. In contrast, they tend to underestimate themselves. They assume that others are just as capable as they are, so they fail to recognize their own advantages. This is called the false consensus effect.

虚假一致性效应，嗯，听起来挺有道理。这背后的原因是什么？为什么能力低的人会这么自信？

The false consensus effect—yes, that sounds reasonable. What is the reason behind this? Why are people with low ability so confident?

主要是元认知能力的缺陷。低能力者缺少评估自己错误的知识和技能，导致他们不知道自己不知道，陷入双重困境。

The main reason is a deficit in metacognitive ability. People with low ability lack the knowledge and skills needed to evaluate their own mistakes, which means they do not know what they do not know and fall into a double burden.

“不知道自己不知道”这句话真有哲理。这种认知偏差会有不同阶段吗？

The phrase “not knowing what one does not know” is really thought-provoking. Does this cognitive bias go through different stages?

对，可以分成四个阶段。第一个是愚昧山峰，人们自信满满，但其实不知道自己不知道；然后是绝望之谷，意识到不足，信心跌到谷底；接着是开悟之坡，通过学习逐渐提升认知和自信；最后是平稳高原，达到认知和信心的平衡。

Yes, it can be divided into four stages. The first is the peak of ignorance, where people are full of confidence but do not know what they do not know. Then comes the valley of despair, where they recognize their limitations and their confidence drops sharply. Next is the slope of enlightenment, where learning gradually improves both understanding and confidence. Finally, there is the plateau of sustainability, where cognition and confidence reach a balanced state.

这过程听起来像爬山一样有起伏。它对我们实际生活或者设计有什么启示吗？

This process sounds like climbing a mountain, with ups and downs. Does it have implications for real life or design?

有很多。比如在人机交互设计中，不能盲目给用户提供功能，而是要根据用户的认知水平进行调整。比如编程学习平台，如果一个新手自信地跳过基础课程，其实可能就是邓宁-克鲁格效应的表现。

Yes, many. For example, in human-computer interaction design, we should not blindly provide users with functions, but should adjust them according to users' cognitive levels. For instance, on a programming learning platform, if a beginner confidently skips the basic courses, this may actually be a manifestation of the Dunning-Kruger effect.

对啊，我有个朋友就是这样，觉得自己很懂，结果基础都没打好。那平台怎么帮他们呢？

Exactly. I have a friend who is just like that. He thought he understood everything, but his foundation was not solid at all. How can the platform help such users?

平台可以用即时测试和同龄人水平图给出量化反馈，引导他们选择适合自己的学习路径。尤其在线上环境中，因为缺少面对面交流，更容易出现这种效应。

The platform can provide quantitative feedback through instant tests and peer-level comparison charts, guiding users to choose learning paths that suit their actual level. This is especially important in online environments, where the lack of face-to-face interaction makes this effect more likely to occur.

线上学习确实容易让人迷失自我认知。在招聘或者其他领域，这个效应也有用吗？

Online learning can indeed make it easier for people to lose an accurate sense of self-awareness. Is this effect also useful in recruitment or other fields?

当然！在智能招聘系统中，可以分析候选人的自评分和实际技能测试分数之间的差异，计算认知偏差指数，帮助判断他们的潜力。

Of course. In intelligent recruitment systems, the gap between candidates' self-ratings and their actual skill test scores can be analyzed to calculate a cognitive bias index, which helps assess their potential.

哇，这么说可以避免面试官被过度自信的候选人骗了。大型语言模型，比如 AI，也能用这个效应改进吗？

Wow, so this could help prevent interviewers from being misled by overly confident candidates. Can large language models, such as AI, also be improved using this effect?

没错。训练模型时，可以让它评估自己答案的置信度和准确性，惩罚那些过度自信但错误的回答，促使模型学会更好的自我认知，在不确定时主动询问，而不是乱答。

Exactly. During model training, the model can be asked to evaluate the confidence and accuracy of its own answers. Overconfident but incorrect responses can be penalized, encouraging the model to develop better self-awareness and to ask questions when uncertain rather than giving random answers.

这真是太酷了。感觉邓宁-克鲁格效应不仅解释了人类的认知偏差，还能帮助我们设计更智能的系统。

That is really cool. It seems that the Dunning-Kruger effect not only explains human cognitive bias, but can also help us design more intelligent systems.

对，它让我们更理解自我认知的发展，也提醒我们保持谦虚和不断学习。

Yes. It helps us better understand the development of self-awareness and reminds us to stay humble and keep learning.

嗯。听你这么说，我突然觉得自己也可能在某些方面高估了自己，得多反思反思。

Yes. After hearing your explanation, I suddenly feel that I may also overestimate myself in some areas, so I should reflect more carefully.

我也是。其实意识到这个偏差，就是开悟之坡的开始。

Me too. In fact, becoming aware of this bias is the beginning of the slope of enlightenment.

说得好，我们以后一起努力，避免陷入愚昧山峰吧。

Well said. Let's work together in the future and try to avoid falling into the peak of ignorance.

没错，一起加油。学习和认知永远在路上。

Exactly. Let's keep going together. Learning and cognition are always ongoing processes.

嗯，感谢你分享这么多，今天学到了不少。

Thank you for sharing so much. I learned a lot today.

我也很开心能和你讨论，感觉理解更深了。下次我们再聊其他有趣的心理学现象吧。

I am also glad to discuss this with you. I feel that my understanding has become deeper. Next time, let's talk about another interesting psychological phenomenon.